Lashkar's leaders also tried to have it both ways after 9/11. The jihad to liberate Indian-administered Kashmir brought with it significant state support for Lashkar, enabling it to grow militarily as well as to establish a robust social services apparatus, which the group used to pursue its missionary objectives in Pakistan. Lashkar had won its spurs in Kashmir, becoming the state's most reliable proxy there. Moreover, its leaders continued to view this as the most legitimate of jihads and also placed a premium on protecting the group's infrastructure in Pakistan. As a result, Lashkar remained more amenable to the Musharraf regime's agenda after 9/11 than any other outfit, focusing primarily on the fight against India and on expanding its social outreach. However, the global jihad was impossible to ignore and Lashkar also began contributing to the fight against America and its allies. Viewed through one lens, it remained a Pakistani proxy against India; through another it seemed to behave like an al-Qaeda associate. And to segments of the population in Pakistan, it appeared to be primarily a social welfare provider. The group's growth during this decade was due in large part to its ability to continue harmonizing operations in these different spheres; an approach which benefited from the fact that it remained more cohesive and methodical than most of its militant brethren in Pakistan. However, as with Pakistan's decision to divide its militants, attempting to balance these competing identities is a recipe for internal discord.

Tensions emerged after 9/11 over the leadership's adherence to the Musharraf regime's agenda and were exacerbated during the middle of the decade when state support for the Kashmir jihad slowed while the insurgency against America and its allies in Afghanistan simultaneously gained strength. Lashkar subsequently opened up a second front there, though its leaders continued to place a premium on liberating Kashmir. Waging jihad in Afghanistan exposed its cadres to outfits that not only prioritized bringing the fight to the US, but also to waging war in Pakistan. This put pressure on the leadership to expand further the scope and scale of its jihad, which contributed to the audacity of the 2008 Mumbai attacks and the inclusion of foreign targets. The assault on Mumbai had minimal impact on Lashkar's ability to operate as a result of the group's continued utility as a proxy, its prominent role as a social welfare provider and the possible consequences that taking serious action against it could bring. Since November 2008 its militant activities in Afghanistan and throughout South